

NAPA DAV316

Elegantly designed with a sweet colour combination, the NAPA DAV316 immediately captured our hearts. A CD-based MP3 solution, this unit performed very well in our sound quality tests delivering both good bass and excellent treble. It had large, easy-to-use buttons on the front panel and an elegant LCD display for ID3 information and navigation. The ID3 tag support displays the song being played, the name of the artiste and the album from which the number is taken. Its 120-second anti-shock protection puts it in the same league as the Creative DAP CD0001—this feature lets you enjoy your favourite



tracks on the move, without worrying about skipping a beat. The unit supports MP3 audio on a CD, CD-R or a CD-RW medium, along with normal Audio CDs. It's bundled with NiMH rechargeable batteries—a great feature for the price conscious. The Line Out port the NAPA sports allows you to connect it to an external music system. It also comes with a DC adapter port that lets you run the unit off an electric outlet to save up on the batteries. With a price tag of Rs 5,650, the NAPA DAV316 managed to bag out Best Value award.

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Features	▶▶▶▶▶	
Ease of use	▶▶▶▶▶	
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶	
Warranty & support	▶▶▶▶▶	
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶	
OVERALL	▶▶▶▶▶	

same performance was extended to the treble test, with 5 points. It also presented the English and Hindi tracks with equally good fidelity. The PA-20 did not reproduce the bass track with a quality equal to that of the Philips player (it scored 3 points); it did however perform significantly better with the music tracks, reproducing both vocals and instruments with equal fervour. The D-Link DMP-100 lagged behind the others in terms of sound quality. This was mainly because of the quality of the accompanying earphones. Surprisingly, the sound quality was decent while playing the vocal-heavy Hindi songs. This was mainly because earphones can't deliver high pitch sounds but perform well while playing songs with lots of mids and vocals. NAPA DAV316 and Creative DAP-CD0001 were two players that gave consistently average quality sound across the entire test.

Battery life: To test the battery life, each player was run continuously at full volume, while we noted down the time taken to drain the batteries completely. The Creative PA-20 took the crown by logging more than 420 minutes of playtime on one set of batteries. Even if you used this unit for 2 hours daily, a single pair of batteries will last for at least five days. The PA-20

was followed by the D-Link DMP-100 with 270 minutes of battery life. The Philips eXp401 logged the lowest score amongst the bunch with all its battery power consumed in 73 minutes flat!

Shock absorption test: Being a portable music system, MP3 players will be used, by definition, while travelling or during those long early-morning jogs and walks. This requires a player that will not skip music and is compact. To test the ability of the CD-based players to output music without skipping, we impact-tested them. A thing to keep in mind is that this test was not meant for the solid-state devices, since they have no moving parts to cause the skipping. An impact force was applied to the player (by either shaking it or tapping it) to ascertain if there was any skipping in the tracks being played. Thanks to a healthy use of buffers, all the players passed this test with flying colours, and none of the CD-based MP3 units skipped even a millisecond worth of music.

Warranty and support

Warranty and support are important issues with portable devices, since they are likely to be roughed up during daily

What to Look for while Buying an MP3 Player

- If you desire a portable and compact device, then make sure that the MP3 player you are buying is a solid state device.
- If maximum storage is your priority, a CD-based MP3 device would be an ideal solution.
- See that the player supports both MP3 and WMA formats.
- Ascertain that your player has an upgradeable firmware as this will future-proof your purchase: in case the MP3 audio format goes in for a revision, you will be able to upgrade your firmware via software to support the new format.
- The player should have a big enough LCD screen that is backlit, so that reading the information even in dark areas becomes easy.
- The button placement should allow you to operate the player while it is buckled to a belt or is inside your pocket.

- A rechargeable battery is a must if you intend to use the device frequently.
- A case that would allow for easy carrying is also very important. It will prevent scratches on the LCD screen and will minimise impact damage that might prove fatal to this delicate device.
- A good pair of earphones will complete the MP3 player, allowing it to accurately reproduce your favourite songs.
- Make sure that the MP3 player has a warranty for at least one year.
- A Line Out port is a definite advantage, as you can plug the MP3 player to a home or car music system.
- An upgradeable storage capacity is another great feature to look out for in an MP3 player.
- If you are buying a CD-based MP3 player, ensure that it has an electronic shock protection of at least 100 seconds.

